Geolocation notes for analysts

A place in a report is a claim. Write down the coordinate, the source, and what would show the claim is wrong. This sheet does not find people.

1. Write the coordinate in one form

Pick one format and stick to it in the product. Convert in the working notes, not in the sentence the reader sees.

- Decimal degrees: latitude first, then longitude, with N/S and E/W or an explicit minus for south and west. 27.47 S is not 27.47 N.
- Degrees, minutes, seconds: do not drop the seconds and call it the same point. A minute of latitude is about 1.8 km.
- UTM: zone number and hemisphere belong with the easting and northing. An easting without a zone is not a location.
- MGRS: grid zone designator plus the square. Truncating digits makes a bigger square, not a tidier point.
- Swapped latitude and longitude is the ordinary error. If the point lands in the ocean, check the order before you check the source.

2. Say what the picture actually is

- A pin on a screenshot is a picture of someone else's pin. Record who published it and when you saved the image.
- Name the map scale or the zoom you were looking at. A building at street zoom and a suburb at city zoom are different claims.
- North is not the top of every image. If the source does not mark north, say so.
- A landmark supports a location when a second source shows the same feature. One matching roofline is a lead.

3. File metadata is a field, not a witness

Some image and GPS files carry a coordinate and a timestamp. Record whether that field is present, what it says, and that it can be edited, copied, or stripped. Do not write that a person was at the coordinate because a file says so.

File or source	Coordinate as written	Format	Metadata present? (yes / no / not checked)	What would disprove this

4. Before it goes in the product

- The reader can tell a point from an area. If you only have a suburb, do not publish a six-decimal pin.
- The source is named. "Open sources" is not a source.
- You have stated the date of the observation separately from the date you looked it up.

- You have not used this sheet to locate a private person. It records a place that is already claimed in material you hold.

Worked habit: write the coordinate once, in one format, with the source beside it. If you cannot fill "what would disprove this", you are not ready to brief the location.